

# Session 24: Abraham Surrenders Isaac

## Key Takeaways

- Avraham’s test on the mountain mirrors the humans’ test in the garden. But where the man and woman fail, Avraham succeeds.
- Avraham’s act of total surrender and trust in God is directly attributed to the fear of the Lord.
- The narrator connects this moment to the later practice of sacrifice in the temple, which involves an act of surrender and the trust that God will take care of the rest.

## Avraham’s Passed Test Versus Adam and Eve’s Failed Test

The story contains a wealth of selective vocabulary that hyperlinks to [Genesis 2-3](#) in obvious and subtle ways.

| Genesis 22                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Genesis 2-3                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
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| <p><b>Gen. 22:4, 6</b> And Avraham lifted <b>his eyes</b> (עיניו) <b>and he saw</b> (וירא) ... <b>and he took</b> (ויקח) in his hand the fire <b>and the knife / eater</b> (מאכלת), and the <b>two of them</b> (שניהם) walked on <b>together</b> (יחדו).</p> | <p><b>Gen. 3:6</b> And the woman saw (ותרא) that good was the tree <b>for eating</b> (מאכל), and desirable <b>to the eyes</b> (עינים), and <b>she took</b> (ותקה) from its fruit</p> <p><b>Gen. 2:24-25</b> ... A man clings to his wife and they become one (אחד) flesh. And the <b>two of them</b> (שניהם) were naked and ... they felt no shame.</p> <p><b>Gen. 3:7</b> And <b>the eyes</b> (עיני) <b>of the two of them</b> (שניהם) were opened and they knew that they were naked.</p> |
| <p><b>Gen. 22:7</b> And Yitskhaq said to Avraham and said "Behold, the fire and the wood, <b>but where</b> (איה) is the sheep for the offering?"</p>                                                                                                         | <p><b>Gen. 3:9</b> And Yahweh God called to the human and said, "Where (אי) are you?"</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <p><b>Gen. 22:10</b> And Avraham <b>sent out his hand and took</b> (ידו ויקח) the <b>knife / eater</b> (מאכלת)</p>                                                                                                                                           | <p><b>Gen. 2:9</b> God caused to grow ... every tree for eating (מאכל).</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| <p><i>Avraham Passed, Adam and Eve Failed.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</p>                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

| Genesis 22                                                                                                                 | Genesis 2-3                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                                                                            | <b>Gen. 3:22</b> "...And now, lest he <b>send out his hand</b> (ישלח ידו ולקח) and eat (אכל) from the tree of life"                                                                                                               |
| <b>Gen. 22:12</b> "Now I <b>know</b> (ידע) that you <b>fear God</b> (אלהים)"                                               | <b>Gen. 3:5</b> "You will become like <b>God</b> (אלהים), <b>knowing</b> (ידע) good and <b>evil</b> (רע)."<br><br><b>Gen. 3:22</b> "Behold, the human has become like one of us, <b>knowing</b> (ידע) good and <b>evil</b> (רע)." |
| <b>Gen. 22:13</b> And Avraham lifted <b>his eyes</b> (עיניו), <b>and he saw</b> (וירא) a ram ... <b>and he took</b> (ויקח) | <b>Gen. 3:6</b> And the woman saw (ותרא) that good was the tree <b>for eating</b> (מאכל), and desirable <b>to the eyes</b> (עינים), and <b>she took</b> (ותקח) from its fruit                                                     |
| <b>Gen. 22:16</b> "Because <b>you have done this thing</b> (עשה + הדבר הזה)"                                               | <b>Gen. 3:13</b> And Yahweh God said to the woman, "What <b>is this you have done</b> (מה זאת עשית)?"                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Gen. 22:18</b> " <b>On account of</b> (עקב) the fact that <b>you listened to my voice</b> (שמע + בקול)."                | <b>Gen. 3:17</b> And to the human / man God said, " <b>On account of</b> (כי) <b>you listened to the voice of your wife</b> (שמע + בקול)"                                                                                         |
| <i>Avraham Passed, Adam and Eve Failed. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).</i>              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

These correspondences invite us to compare humanity's primal failure that eventually led to God's choosing of Avraham with Avraham's own faithfulness.

- Adam and Eve were given a divine command that required trust, faithfulness, and surrender of their desire to have knowledge of good and bad on their own terms (Gen. 2:16-17). Avraham is given a divine command to surrender the life of his son over to God's will (Gen. 22:2).
- Adam and Eve's failure is by "taking" (לקח) and "eating" (אכל) from the "tree" (עץ, Gen. 3:6). Avraham's faithfulness is shown through "taking" (לקח) the "eater" (מאכלת) and the "wood/tree" (עץ) for the offering (Gen. 22:6).
- Adam and Eve's failure separated the two (שניהם) God purposed to become one (אחד, Gen. 2:24-25). Avraham's faithfulness results in Avraham and his son ("the two of them" שניהם) walking together as one (יחדו, Gen. 22:8).
- Adam and Eve's failure results in the loss of true life and exile unto death (Gen. 3:22-23). Avraham's faithfulness in surrendering Yitskhaq over to death results in him regaining his son with a new life (Gen. 22:13-18).

"But it is not simply that an extraordinary act of obedience by a righteous man [Abraham] leads to extraordinary blessing. It is that one man's obedience climaxes in an act of sacrifice and thus leads to

extraordinary blessing ... The faithful obedience of Noah culminating in his sacrifices after the flood changed God’s disposition toward sinful humanity. Similarly Abraham’s obedience guaranteed the future of his descendants and that through them blessing should come to all nations.”

Wenham, Gordon (2001). “The Akedah: A Paradigm of Sacrifice.” *Journal of Biblical Literature*, vol. 116, no. 3. 102.

## God’s Response to Avraham: A Blessings Remix

Yahweh’s speech to Avraham is a remix of the entire sequence of blessings up to this point in the story. It deliberately echoes the stories of Adam and Eve, Noah, and every part of the Avraham story in order to show that Avraham’s faithfulness has brought the divine promise to a new level of fulfillment.

| God’s Speech in Genesis 22:15-18                                                             | Earlier Stories of Testing and Blessing                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
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| "On account of the fact that you have done this thing (אשר עשית את הדבר הזה)"                | <p><b>Gen. 3:13</b> And Yahweh God said to the woman, "What <b>is this you have done</b> (מה זאת עשית)?"</p> <p><b>Gen. 12:18</b> And Pharaoh called out ... " <b>What is this you have done to me</b> (מה זאת עשית לי)?"</p> <p><b>Gen. 20:10</b> And Avimelek said to Avraham, "What did you see, <b>that you have done this thing</b> (כי עשית את הדבר הזה)?"</p>                                                     |
| "You have not withheld your son, your only one"                                              | <b>Gen. 22:12</b> "Now I know that you fear God, and you did not withhold your son, your only one from me."                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| "I will greatly bless you (ברך אברכך)"                                                       | <p><b>Gen. 1:28</b> And God <b>blessed</b> (ויברך) them and said, "Be fruitful and multiply, fill the land ..."</p> <p><b>Gen. 9:1</b> And God <b>blessed</b> (ויברך) Noah and his sons and said, "Be fruitful and multiply and fill the land."</p> <p><b>Gen. 12:2</b> "I will make you into a great nation and <b>I will bless you</b> (אברכך) and make your name great and you will be a <b>blessing</b> (ברכה)."</p> |
| "I will greatly multiply your seed (הרבה ארבה את זרעך) ..."                                  | <p><b>Gen. 3:16</b> And to the woman he said, " <b>I will greatly multiply</b> (הרבה ארבה) your grief in conception ..."</p> <p><b>Gen. 16:10</b> And the angel said to [Hagar], " <b>I will greatly multiply your</b></p>                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| God’s Response to Avraham. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021). |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |

**God's Speech in Genesis  
22:15-18**

**Earlier Stories of Testing and Blessing**

|                                                                            |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                            | <b>seed</b> (הרבה ארבה את זרעך), and it will not be counted because of its greatness."                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| "... like the stars of the heavens (ככובי השמים)"                          | <b>Gen. 15:5</b> "Look up <b>at the heavens</b> (השמימה) and count <b>the stars</b> (כוכבים) if you are able ... that what your seed will be."                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| "And like the sand which is on the lip of the sea"                         | <b>Gen. 13:15</b> "I will set <b>your seed like the dust of the land</b> (בעפר הארץ) if someone is able to count the <b>dust of the land</b> , they'll also be able to count <b>your seed</b> ."                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| "And your seed will inherit the gate of their enemies"                     | <p><b>Gen. 24:60</b> And they blessed Rivqah and said ... "<b>May your seed inherit the gate</b> (ויירש זרעך את שער שנאיו) of their haters."</p> <p><b>Num. 24:17-18</b> A star treads from Yaaqov, a staff arises from Israel ... and Edom will be <b>a possession</b> (ירשה), and <b>Seir his enemy will be a possession</b> (ירשה שעיר איביו).</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| "And through your seed all the nations of the land will discover blessing" | <p><b>Gen. 12:3</b> "And <b>through you</b> (בך) all the families of the land will find blessing (נברכו)."</p> <p><b>Gen. 18:18</b> Avraham will become a great nation and mighty, and all <b>the nations of the land</b> (גויי הארץ) <b>will find blessing</b> (נברכו) <b>through him</b> (בו).</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| "On account of (עקב) the fact that you listened to my voice (שמע + בקול)"  | <p><b>Gen. 3:15</b> "Her seed (זרע) will strike your head, and you will strike <b>his heel</b> (עקב)."</p> <p><b>Gen. 3:8</b> And <b>they heard the voice / sound</b> (שמע + קול) of God walking in the garden</p> <p><b>Gen. 3:10</b> "And <b>I heard your voice/sound</b> (שמע + קול) in the garden and I was afraid"</p> <p><b>Gen. 3:17</b> And to the human/man God said, "<b>On account of</b> (כי) <b>you listened to the voice of your wife</b> (שמע + לקול)"</p> <p><b>Gen. 16:2</b> And Avraham <b>listened to the voice of Sarai</b> (שמע + לקול).</p> <p><b>Gen. 21:12</b> "Everything which Sarah tells you, <b>listen to her voice</b> (שמע + בקול)"</p> |

*God's Response to Avraham.* Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

**Gen. 26:5** "On account of the fact that (עקב) **Avraham listened to my voice** (שמע + בקול)"

\*Notice the contrast "listening" moments: (1) People can listen to the human voice (Adam & Eve, Abe to Sarah) resulting in disaster and "listening" to Yahweh's voice coming in judgment; or (2) People can listen to God's voice the first time (Avraham in Gen. 22), resulting in blessing.

*God's Response to Avraham.* Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

## Retrospective on the Design Shape of Genesis 20-22

As noted above, Genesis 20-22 has a forward symmetry design shape (ABA'B') that relates the four stories in a specific way. There is, however, an overlapping design shape based on other features of these stories that creates a different set of relationships between the stories.

### Genesis 20:1-18

#### A - Avraham's Deception Places Sarah in Danger, but God Delivers

- Avraham's deceitful lie about Sarah places her in danger.
- Innocent Avimelek wrongly takes Sarah as his wife, placing his life and future seed in danger.
- **20:11** Avraham assumed there was no **"fear of God"** (יראת אלהים) in Gerar, when, in fact, there was, and he was the one who didn't fear God.
- **20:6** God prevents innocent Avimelek from sinning unto death: **"I know that (ידעתי כי)"** you did this with wholeness of heart, and so **I withheld you from (חשך מ-)** sinning against me."

### Genesis 21:1-21

#### B - Rival Wives and Sons Are Separated and Not Reconciled

- Hagar and Ishmael are banished because of Sarah's jealous anger.
- **21:14** That anger leads to a near death, but God delivers through the waters of "the Well of Seven/oath" (Beer-Sheva / באר שבע).
- **21:19** "And she saw the **well of water (באר מים)** and went and filled the water skin."

### Genesis 21:22-34

#### B' - Rival Brothers Are Reconciled Through a Covenant Oath

- **21:28-33** Avraham and Avimelek create peace through a seven (שבע) animal exchange that leads to the two of them making a covenant (ברית) and an oath (שבע), at "Well of Seven/oath" (Beer-Sheva / באר שבע).
- **21:25** "And Avraham disputed with Avimelek on account of a **well of water** (באר המים)." .

### Genesis 22:1-19

#### A' - Avraham's Sins Place Issac in Danger, but God Delivers

- Avraham and Sarah's sins against Hagar are brought to account through God's test.
- Innocent Issac is to suffer for Avraham's sins, placing Avraham's future seed in danger.
- **22:12** God prevents innocent Issac from dying for Avraham's sins: "Now **I know that** (ידעתי כי) **you** **fear God**, and **you did not withhold from** (השך מ-) me your son, your only one."

Genesis 20:1-22:19 (Version 2). Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

## God Rescues Avraham From Danger and From the Consequences of His Own Sins (Gen. 20:1-18 and 22:1-19)

The opening and closing stories are about how Avraham's sins against others (Avimelek, Hagar and Yishmael) affect the innocent people around him.

- Avraham's deception about Sarah leads innocent Avimelek to wrongfully take another man's wife.
- Avraham and Sarah's mistreatment of Hagar (Gen. 16) leads to Sarah's jealous anger (Gen. 21:9-10) and the expulsion of Hagar and her son.

In both cases God "prevents" (חשך) the sin from reaching a lethal consequence.

- God intervenes through a dream and prevents (חשך) Avimelek from "touching" Sarah (Gen. 20:6).
- God intervenes through an angel and prevents Avraham from "butchering" Yitskhaq (Gen. 22:11-12).

In both cases, Avraham's sin places the future of his descendants (and God's promise) in danger.

- In Genesis 20, Avraham's sin puts Sarah in danger.
- In Genesis 22, Avraham and Sarah's sin puts Yitskhaq in danger.

## Rivals Are Either Separated or Reconciled (Gen. 21:1-21 and 21:22-34)

The two inner stories are about how Avraham's sin creates two rivalries that end with opposite conclusions.

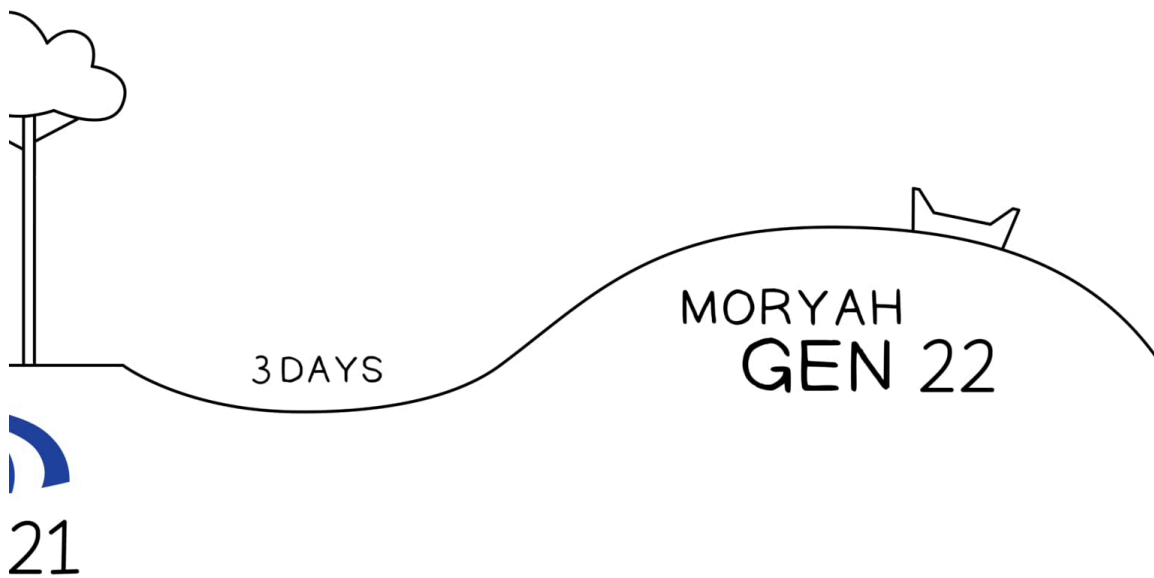
- In Genesis 21:1-21, the rivalry between Sarah and Hagar (and Yitskhaq and Yishmael) leads to separation and near death that is only resolved by the provision of water at "Well of Seven/Oath."
- In Genesis 21:22-34, the rivalry between Avraham and Avimelek leads to a reconciliation and covenant at "Well of Seven/Oath."

In both stories, the focus is on the future well-being of later descendants.

- In Genesis 21:13 and 21, God guarantees that Yishmael will have future seed (זרע) who will become a great nation, and the story concludes with Hagar providing a wife for her son.
- In Genesis 21:22-23, Avimelek wants to guarantee the well-being of his future seed and progeny (נין ונכד) through a covenant with Avraham.

## Avraham's Surrender as Fear of the Lord

# "TEST"



*Avraham's Hilltop Sacrifice Pattern. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).*

## Reflection Question

Based on Genesis 22:1-19, what does the fear of the Lord look like?